

The Post-Surgery Rebuild Roadmap

4 priorities to understand when you still do not feel right after colorectal surgery

Ostomy • Preparing for Reversal • J-Pouch • Post-Reversal

If surgery saved your life but you still feel like your life revolves around your abdomen, bowel function, food decisions, weakness, restrictions, or fear of the next setback, this guide is for you.

I went through 20+ surgeries, an ileostomy, a J-pouch, severe adhesions, scar-tissue blockages, anastomotic strictures, stents, a fistula and abscess, and a point where a permanent ostomy was on the table. The biggest lesson was that surviving surgery and rebuilding afterward are two different jobs.

This roadmap is not a universal protocol. It is a way to organize the pieces so you can see what deserves attention first.

1. ASSESS: Know the body you are rebuilding

After multiple surgeries, it is easy to think only in terms of the latest symptom. Start by zooming out. Your current body is the result of your surgical history, anatomy, nutrition, activity, scars, recovery, stress, and what happened between procedures.

Your Rebuild Snapshot

- What surgeries and procedures have you had, and when?
- What anatomy do you have now: ostomy, J-pouch, reversal, other?
- What are the 1-3 problems that affect daily life the most?
- What activities have you stopped doing or become afraid to do?
- What have you tried already, and what changed?
- Is another surgery/procedure being discussed or scheduled?

The goal is not to solve everything at once. It is to identify what matters most right now.

2. STABILIZE: Give the body enough capacity to rebuild

Before chasing advanced exercises or a dozen supplements, look at the basics that determine how much recovery capacity you have available.

- Nutrition: are you consistently getting enough food and protein for your current needs and tolerances?
- Hydration: is your fluid/electrolyte strategy working for your current anatomy and output?
- Digestion/tolerance: which foods leave you feeling stable versus depleted, bloated, or fearful?
- Sleep and recovery: are you recovering between days, or living in a constant deficit?
- Stress load: is your body spending every day in “what goes wrong next?” mode?

Your plan should fit the body you have now, not the diet or routine you followed before surgery.

3. RESTORE: Relearn how the trunk, abdomen, pelvis, and breath work together

Surgery changes more than a piece of bowel. Incisions, guarding, time in bed, pain, scars, fear of movement, and repeated procedures can change the way you breathe and move.

Depending on your history, rebuilding may include work around breathing mechanics, trunk and pelvic coordination, mobility, body awareness, scar restrictions, walking, and movement quality. Hands-on work can be useful for some people, while others need a different starting point.

Do not copy someone else's "scar release" or exercise plan just because their surgery sounds similar. The value is matching the work to your history and response.

4. REBUILD: Progress from protection to capability

The long-term goal is not to spend your life protecting your abdomen. It is to progressively build a body you trust.

- Build core and trunk capacity rather than avoiding them forever.
- Progress strength and exercise in steps instead of jumping from "do nothing" to normal training.
- Choose real-life goals: walking farther, traveling, lifting, playing with your kids, returning to the gym, sleeping better, or getting through a day without constantly monitoring your body.
- Track what improves and what consistently sets you back so the plan gets smarter over time.

The question to ask when you feel stuck

"What is the next bottleneck in my rebuild - and do I need information, medical care, hands-on help, or a personalized plan to address it?"

That question is more useful than collecting another fifty disconnected tips.

When you want a personalized plan

I work privately with people who have an ostomy, J-pouch, or reversal - including people preparing for another procedure - to organize the whole picture and build a practical next-step plan.

The 30-Day Post-Surgery Rebuild Intensive includes four private sessions, a Personal Rebuild Map, individualized routines/resources, and between-session support.

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